

The Mirror Maze of Maps

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Aisle of Silver Glass

The Labyrinth Library was not like ordinary libraries. Its shelves spiralled upward into a ceiling lost in purple mist, its lanterns burned with soft gold that smelled faintly of cinnamon, and somewhere deep in its heart, a place existed that very few readers ever found on purpose.

Natalia discovered the entrance by accident.

She had been searching for a book about cartography — the art of making maps — when her foot caught the edge of a particular floor tile. The tile tilted, just a centimetre, and a low, melodic hum rose from the wall beside her. The bookshelf swung inward like a door, and beyond it, where ordinary shelves should have been, stretched a long corridor lined entirely with mirrors.

Every mirror was framed differently. One had a border of twisted copper vines. Another was set in dark wood carved with tiny owls. A third had no frame at all, its edges fading into the stone wall as though the mirror had grown there naturally. And on each mirror, pinned or tucked into the frame, were maps.

Maps of forests. Maps of cities. Maps of mountains, oceans, underground caves, and cloudscape that surely couldn't exist. They rustled softly even though there was no wind.

"Woah," said Natalia.

She had barely finished the word when three more people appeared behind her: Maya, who had been looking for a Spanish poetry anthology; Alana, who had been trying to find the bathroom and was quite embarrassed about it; and SPARK, the small glowing companion who travelled everywhere with the girls, his circuits humming with curiosity.

"A mirror aisle," SPARK said. His glow shifted from blue to gold. "I have fourteen catalogued references to mirror aisles in magical libraries. None of them end simply."

"Does that mean we should leave?" Alana asked.

Natalia looked at the nearest map. It showed a path through a dark wood, leading to a bright clearing with something gleaming at its centre. The path seemed to shimmer, as though it were alive.

"I think," Natalia said slowly, "we should look more carefully before we decide anything."

Maya was already reading the label beneath the first mirror. The handwriting was old and looping. It said: *The Map Shows Only What You Believe You Want.*

None of them understood what that meant. Not yet.

SPARK's glow pulsed once, uneasy. The maps rustled again, and the door behind them swung quietly closed.

Chapter 2 — Maps That Lie

Natalia chose the first map because the path on it looked clear and well-lit. It showed a trail through a gentle wood, winding toward a hilltop where a small stone tower stood. At the top of the tower, drawn in careful ink, was a crown.

"A crown?" Maya said, leaning over Natalia's shoulder.

"Maybe it's a metaphor," Natalia said. She had been reading a lot about metaphors lately.

SPARK scanned the map with one of his sensor beams. "Interesting. The map is showing you a destination. But I notice the path changes slightly depending on who is holding it."

He was right. When Maya held the map, the tower vanished and in its place appeared a stage — a small but brilliant one, lit by theatre lights. When Alana took it, the destination shifted again: a library within a library, with shelves stretching to infinity. When SPARK touched it with his sensor, the map went entirely blank for three full seconds before fading back.

"It shows different things to different people," Maya said. "But it shows them what they want."

"What I want is to find the exit," Alana said.

"That's not quite true," SPARK said gently. Alana opened her mouth to argue, then closed it. She wasn't entirely sure he was wrong.

They decided to follow the path the map had shown Natalia, since she had found the aisle first. It seemed only fair. The mirrors watched them as they walked deeper into the corridor, and Natalia noticed something strange: the reflections in the mirrors did not always match what was happening. When she raised her right hand, her reflection raised its left. When Maya laughed, her reflection in a nearby mirror looked worried instead.

"Something is wrong with these mirrors," Maya said quietly.

"I think the mirrors are showing us the opposite of what we project," SPARK said. "They're designed to make you question what you see."

That was when the path on the map abruptly changed. The gentle wood disappeared. The hilltop tower vanished. Instead, the map now showed a tangle of passages with no clear direction, looping back on themselves in increasingly confusing patterns.

They had entered the maze part of the Mirror Maze of Maps.

And there was no visible way back.

Chapter 3 — Rival Paths

The corridor had divided. Natalia stood at a fork, one passage curving left and glowing a warm amber, the other curving right and glowing cool silver. Both passages were lined with mirrors. Both had maps pinned along their

walls.

"Left," said Natalia. "Warm light usually means welcome."

"Right," said Maya at exactly the same moment. "The silver maps look more detailed. Detail means accuracy."

They looked at each other.

Alana sighed. "This is how every adventure starts going wrong."

She wasn't saying it unkindly. She just had older sisters and knew the pattern.

SPARK consulted the map they'd been following, but it had gone blank again. It did that whenever someone felt confused — or so he theorised. "There may not be a correct path," he said. "The maze might be testing something other than navigation."

"Like what?" Natalia asked.

"Why do you want to follow the left path?" he asked her.

"I told you. Warm light."

"But why does that feel safer to you?"

Natalia thought about it. She was the oldest of the Allen girls and had always been the one who led, who decided, who carried the group forward. She liked certainty. She liked clear answers. She liked feeling as though she knew where she was going.

"Because I don't want to be uncertain," she said, finally. "I want to know I'm right."

SPARK's light pulsed. "And Maya. Why the silver path?"

Maya crossed her arms, but not defensively. She was thinking. "Because I want it to be more complex. I want there to be more to discover. I always feel like things are being oversimplified for me."

"Neither of you is looking for a destination," SPARK said. "You're looking for confirmation of who you already are."

The maps on the walls rustled in what sounded — absurdly — like agreement.

A third option neither of them had noticed before revealed itself: straight ahead, where the two passages bent away, the wall had a low door. It was easy to miss because it was the same stone colour as the wall and had no handle. Only a small handprint shape was pressed into it, as though someone had once leaned against it while thinking hard.

Alana was the one who pressed her palm to the print.

The door swung open.

Beyond it was a passage that had no colour at all — just plain, honest grey stone lit by simple lanterns — and it went forward without turning.

Chapter 4 — SPARK's Compass

The plain passage was longer than it looked.

They walked for what felt like ten minutes, their footsteps echoing off stone. The mirrors here were smaller, set at eye level every few metres, and they showed nothing but the girls themselves — real reflections, accurate ones, no tricks.

"I think the maze is calming down," Maya said. "Or it's letting us calm down."

"Both, perhaps," said SPARK. He had been quiet since the fork, processing something.

Natalia noticed he was holding something in his small mechanical hand. A compass, but not like any compass she had seen. It was golden, the size of a large coin, and its needle did not point north. It spun slowly, as though searching.

"Where did you get that?" she asked.

"It was pinned to a map back at the second mirror," SPARK said. "I thought it might be useful. I didn't mention it immediately because I wasn't sure what it measured." He turned it in the light. "I believe I understand now. It points toward genuine intent."

"What does that mean?" Alana asked.

"When you truly know what you're looking for — not what you think you want, not what you think you should want, but what you actually, honestly need — the needle settles. Until then, it spins."

Natalia took it gently and held it. The needle spun. She handed it to Maya. Still spinning. Alana tried. Spinning.

"Does it work for you?" Natalia asked SPARK.

He held it himself. The needle slowed, trembled, and stopped, pointing straight ahead down the corridor.

"It works for me," he said, "because I know exactly what I want. To help you find your way through."

That simple answer settled over the girls like a warm blanket.

They kept walking. The corridor widened gradually, and the walls began to carry more maps again, but these were

different from the ones at the entrance. These were older. The ink was faded, the paper yellowed. Some had notes in the margins — small, cramped handwriting that looked like a child's.

Maya stopped at one and read aloud: *"If you go left here you find the reading room but the reading room never ends. Don't go left."*

The note was not printed. It was personal. It was a warning.

Someone had been here before. Someone who had struggled.

Natalia looked at the date written in the corner of the map. It was very, very old.

Chapter 5 — The Map That Shows Nothing

At the heart of one of the mirror corridors, tucked into the frame of the largest mirror they had yet seen, was a map unlike any other.

It was blank.

Not faded, not worn away, not obscured by the dim light. Completely, deliberately blank. The paper was fine and heavy, slightly cream-coloured at the edges where age had touched it, but the centre was white as fresh snow. At the top, in very small letters, someone had written a title: *For When You Are Ready.*

"For when we're ready for what?" Alana asked.

Nobody answered, because nobody knew.

Natalia reached out and took the map from the frame. The moment her fingers touched it, something happened. A single line appeared — not a path, not a road, but a dot. Just one dot, somewhere near the middle of the page.

"That's us," Maya said quietly. She wasn't guessing. She knew.

SPARK confirmed it. "The dot is moving as we move. This map is tracking our location within the maze." He paused. "But it shows nothing else. No walls, no passages, no exits."

"So it's useless," Alana said.

"Or it's telling us something," Natalia said. She held the map flat and studied the single dot. "It shows where we are. But not where we're going. Maybe that's because we haven't decided yet."

Maya took the map and held it. For a long moment, nothing changed. Then, very slowly, a second dot appeared — faint, flickering — far to the upper right of the page.

"What's that?" Natalia asked.

"I don't know," Maya said. But her voice had changed. It was softer, slightly uncertain, and SPARK, who was very good at reading voices, noted it carefully.

"May I ask you something?" he said to Maya.

She handed the map back without looking at him. "If you're going to ask what I really want," she said, "I'm not ready to answer that yet."

"That's alright," SPARK said. "The maze seems patient."

They rested there for a while, sitting on the floor of the corridor with their backs against the mirrors. It was warm. The lanterns overhead burned a steady gold. The maps on the walls rustled, but gently now, like the sound of pages being turned by a careful reader.

Above them, the mirrors showed their reflections — accurate ones — and all four of them, for the first time since entering, looked exactly like themselves.

Chapter 6 — What Natalia Truly Seeks

Natalia had been thinking for a long time. Long enough that Maya had taken out a small notebook and begun writing, and Alana had fallen asleep briefly with her head resting against SPARK's shoulder.

Natalia was thinking about the crown on the first map — the one that had appeared when she held it.

She had told herself it was a metaphor. But she was not sure that was true.

What she had really thought, the instant she saw it, was: **that's mine**. A hot, private certainty. As though the crown was something she had been working toward without admitting it, something she wanted in a way that embarrassed her.

To lead. To be the best. To be the one the others followed.

And sitting in the honest light of the mirror corridor, with the blank map resting in her lap, she understood why that embarrassed her: because it sounded selfish, and she didn't want to be selfish.

She took the blank map and held it.

A line began to draw itself. Slowly, tracing a route through the maze — not toward a crown, but toward something else. She squinted at the tiny symbol at the end of the line. It was not a crown. It was a circle with four smaller circles around it.

A leader at the centre of a group.

Her throat tightened in a way that was not sadness and not happiness but something between the two.

"SPARK," she said quietly, so as not to wake Alana. "I think I know what I want."

"Tell me," he said.

"I want to be someone that people genuinely follow. Not because I make them. Because they trust me." She swallowed. "That's different from just wanting to be in charge."

SPARK's light changed — it became the deepest, steadiest gold she had ever seen from him. "It is very different," he agreed.

The compass in his hand, which had been spinning since she'd last held it, slowed. She reached out and took it. The needle trembled. Then, for the first time since they'd entered the maze, it pointed somewhere for her: down a passage they hadn't yet explored, one that had appeared in the wall behind them while they'd been sitting still.

The maze had heard her.

It was time to move.

Chapter 7 — Maya's Hidden Wish

The new passage curved gently and led them into a hexagonal room where every wall was a mirror and every mirror held a different map. The maps here were of interior spaces: the floor plan of a concert hall, the layout of a recording studio, the architecture of an amphitheatre carved into a clifftop overlooking the sea.

Maya stopped walking the moment she stepped inside.

She stood very still, looking at the concert hall map. Then at the amphitheatre. Then back at the hall.

"Maya," Natalia said gently.

"I'm fine," Maya said.

"You haven't said anything since the blank map room."

Maya sat down on the floor in the middle of the hexagonal room, which was not very dignified but felt necessary. She put her head in her hands.

"I want to perform," she said. "I mean really perform. Not just sing along at school. Not just in front of you lot. I want — I want people to hear me." Her voice was muffled by her hands. "And I feel absolutely ridiculous saying that out loud."

"Why?" Alana asked. She had woken up during the walk and was fully present now. "That's not ridiculous."

"Because what if I'm not good enough? What if wanting it that much means I'm arrogant?"

SPARK crouched beside her. "Wanting something deeply is not arrogance. Arrogance is believing you deserve it without earning it. You want to earn it. Those are not the same thing."

Maya looked up at him. Her eyes were shining.

"Also," said Alana, "you have a genuinely lovely voice. This is a fact, not a compliment."

Maya laughed in spite of herself. It was a short, watery laugh, but it was real.

She stood up and took the blank map. The route it drew was immediate this time — quick and direct, as though the maze had already known and was simply waiting for her to catch up. At the end of the route, the tiny symbol was a pair of cupped hands holding a sound wave.

A voice, held carefully. Given freely.

"Alright," Maya said, composing herself with the dignity of someone who had briefly not been dignified and had made peace with that. "Let's keep going."

The walls of the hexagonal room parted. Not dramatically — just quietly, the way understanding tends to arrive.

Chapter 8 — Alana and the Locked Door

The next obstacle was a door.

It was tall, old, made of dark wood reinforced with iron hinges, and it had three locks. Each lock had a keyhole, but there were no keys anywhere nearby. Instead, below each keyhole was a small plaque, and each plaque asked a question:

What do you love that you have never told anyone?

What are you afraid people will think if they know you?

What is the truest, most honest thing about you?

Natalia and Maya had already answered their versions of these questions, in their own way, in earlier rooms. The maze seemed to know that. When they tried the door, it didn't respond to them at all. Not rudely — just still, as though it was simply not theirs to open.

The door was waiting for Alana.

Alana stood before it for a very long time.

She was the youngest of the three girls and very often the one who laughed first, worried least, and said the sensible thing. She had a reputation among her sisters as the practical one. The grounded one. The one who found the bathroom and couldn't find the adventure.

"Libraries," she said finally.

Natalia and Maya looked at her.

"I love libraries. I mean — I really love them. Not just for the books. I love that they keep things safe. I love that they exist for everyone. I love that they're quiet but not lonely." She spoke faster as she went. "I've never told anyone because it sounds boring. But it's not boring to me. It's the best feeling I know."

The first lock clicked open.

"I'm afraid," she continued, her voice steady, "that people think I'm boring. That being quiet and loving libraries and liking order means there's nothing interesting in me."

Second lock.

She faced the third plaque. *What is the truest, most honest thing about you?*

She took a breath.

"I'm a keeper," she said. "Not a finder. Not an explorer. I want to be the person who makes sure the beautiful things stay found. I want to take care of the things that matter." Her voice was very steady. "That's who I am."

Third lock.

The door opened.

Beyond it, the maze opened into a large and beautiful circular room — and in the centre of it stood an old woman, very small, wrapped in a dark green shawl, looking at them with wide, tired eyes.

Chapter 9 — The Librarian's Secret

The old woman's name was Wren.

She had the kind of face that held its age openly — a thousand small lines around her eyes, white hair that had once been very dark, hands that had clearly handled a great many books over a great many years. She was not frightening. She was not alarming in any way. But she was clearly someone who had been somewhere very long, and the room around her told the whole story.

She had made the maze.

Not the whole Labyrinth Library — that was older than anyone could quite explain — but this particular place, the Mirror Maze of Maps, was entirely her creation. The mirrors, the maps, the compass, the blank map that showed only where you were. All of it. She had built it over decades, piece by piece.

"I got lost here," she said. She had a quiet voice, matter-of-fact. "When I was six years old. This was before the

maze existed. I wandered into a disused wing and couldn't find my way out for three days."

"Three days?" Alana said, aghast.

"I had water. I had books. I was frightened, but I was also—" Wren paused. "I was discovering something. That when you are truly lost, you find out very quickly what matters to you. What you're really afraid of. What you actually want."

She looked at the girls steadily.

"I built this maze so that children who came here after me would have the same experience, but with guidance. With maps that tell the truth when you're ready to hear it. With a compass that settles when you know yourself."

"You built a maze out of a bad experience," Maya said slowly, "to help people."

"Not just a bad experience. The most important one of my life." Wren smiled. It was a small, dry smile, but warm underneath. "I became the Head Librarian of this place. I spent seventy years here. I've watched hundreds of children walk into this maze confused and walk out knowing themselves a little better."

"Did you ever walk out?" Natalia asked.

Wren looked at her carefully. "I just told you I spend seventy years here."

"I mean — did you ever leave the library? Go somewhere else?"

A long pause. "No," Wren said. "I never did. There was always more to keep."

Alana and she looked at each other, and something passed between them — a recognition, quiet as a library.

Chapter 10 — The Heart of the Maze

Wren led them deeper.

She moved with the ease of someone who knew every turning of a place not because she had memorised it, but because it was part of her — the way a gardener knows their own garden, the way a musician knows a song they have played a thousand times.

The heart of the maze was a circular room with a domed ceiling, and the ceiling was a single enormous mirror.

The girls looked up and saw themselves, small and clear, reflected in the dome above. They looked younger somehow. Simpler. Four figures standing in a circle, looking up at themselves looking down.

Around the perimeter of the room were twelve maps in ornate frames, one for each month of the year according to the calendar plaques beneath them. Each map showed the same location — the library — but from a different perspective. One from above. One from below. One through the eyes of a child who had never been there. One

through the eyes of someone who had spent their whole life there.

"The twelve maps of the library," Wren said. "One truth, twelve perspectives. None of them wrong. None of them complete."

In the centre of the room was a pedestal, and on the pedestal was a blank map — but larger than the one they'd been carrying. The full page. And at the very centre of the blank page, drawn in gold ink, were four names:

Natalia. Maya. Alana. SPARK.

Below the names, in smaller letters: *You were never lost. You were finding your way to here.*

Natalia stood at the pedestal and stared at their names. "So the maze — it was leading us here the whole time?"

"The maze leads you to the truth of yourself," Wren said. "Which for you four, in this particular journey, happened to be here. But for someone else, the heart might be in a different room entirely."

SPARK held up the golden compass. The needle was pointing straight down at the pedestal.

"Intent met," he said softly. "All four of us, at the same time."

The compass glowed. And then, from the centre of the room's floor, something else appeared: a door handle, previously invisible, rising from the stone like a plant finding sunlight.

The way out had been underneath them the entire time.

Chapter 11 — The Golden Compass

Before they left, Wren gave each of them something.

To Natalia, she gave a small book with blank pages. "Leaders write," she said. "Not orders. Thoughts. Reflections. You'll understand when you begin."

To Maya, she gave a single music note pressed in brass, no larger than a thumbnail, on a thin chain. "A reminder," she said, "that the thing you want is already inside you. The world will give it an audience, but the note itself is yours."

To Alana, she gave a ring of keys — small ones, old ones, each labelled in tiny print with the names of rooms in the library that did not appear on any public map. "You said you wanted to be a keeper," Wren said. "These are for whenever you're ready to begin."

Alana held the keys with great care.

To SPARK, Wren gave nothing except a long, appraising look. "You already have what you need," she said. "You've had it the whole time. That's why the compass worked for you first." She paused. "Thank you for keeping

them safe in here."

"That's what I'm for," SPARK said.

"No," Wren said. "That's what you *choose*. There's a difference. Keep choosing it."

SPARK's light burned very steadily after that.

Then Natalia reached for the golden compass. SPARK had been holding it, but he offered it without hesitation.

"For the way home?" Natalia asked Wren.

"Hold it and think — not about where you want to go, but about why you want to go there. Think about the people waiting for you. Think about what you've learned and what you want to carry back into the world."

Natalia closed her fingers around the compass. She thought of their room in the library. She thought of the soft chairs and the smell of old paper. She thought of what it felt like to sit down with people you trusted and discover something together.

The needle settled. Pointed directly upward.

Through the door handle, through the floor, through the heart of the maze.

They climbed.

Chapter 12 — The Way Out Is In

The door in the floor opened onto a staircase, and the staircase led upward through warm amber light, and the staircase came out through a familiar bookshelf that swung aside as they approached — the same one Natalia had stumbled against at the very beginning.

They stepped out into the ordinary part of the Labyrinth Library, and it was just as it had been: tall shelves and purple mist and lanterns that smelled of cinnamon.

Except it felt different.

Not the library. The library was the same. But they were not.

Natalia looked at the shelf they had emerged from. The tile on the floor was ordinary again, flush with the rest. No hum. No door. She pressed it gently with her foot and nothing happened.

"It won't open again for us," SPARK said. "I believe it only opens for those who haven't found it yet."

"That's how the best things work," Maya said.

They found their things where they'd left them — Maya's bag on a reading table, Natalia's book still open to the cartography chapter, Alana's library card sitting patiently on the shelf where she'd set it down before going looking for the bathroom.

She picked up her library card and looked at it. Then looked at the keys Wren had given her.

"I'm going to ask the librarian at the front desk about volunteer programmes," she said.

Natalia smiled. "I thought you might."

"I'm going to start practising voice properly," Maya said. "I found a choir at school I've been ignoring." She touched the brass music note at her throat. "I think I'll stop ignoring it."

SPARK looked between all three of them. His light was the colour of afternoon sun through clear water. "And you?" he asked Natalia.

She held the blank book Wren had given her. She did not open it yet, but she ran her thumb across the cover.

"I'm going to write down what I want," she said. "Honestly. Not what sounds good. What is true." She looked up. "And then I'm going to work toward it without pretending I don't want it."

The library hummed around them. Somewhere in its deep interior, maps rustled, mirrors reflected, and a small golden compass sat on a pedestal in a circular room, its needle perfectly still, pointing toward something only hearts could read.

They gathered their things and walked out into the world.

THE END